

*Dear Wilhelm,*

*Your letter arrived Tuesday and I have read it three times, chiefly because I could hear you preening through the ink. A repaired road, an honest butcher, a Bürgermeister shaking your hand in the square – you built the town a clock and it has thanked you by becoming respectable. I am delighted for you, old friend, and not at all surprised. You never could make a thing that worked only as well as it needed to.*

*I will believe the half of it that flatters the town and suspect the half that flatters the clock. Fevers pass and roads get mended, even without a marvel ticking over them. But I know better than to argue with you about measurements. You counted the stones of my garden path the summer you stayed with us, and informed me that two were loose. If you say the thing is perfect, then it is perfect.*

*As for the woodcarver and his identical chairs – Wilhelm, you are making too much of a clock. A man may find his best pattern late in life and be content to repeat it. Not every regularity in the world is your doing. It is a fine tower and an honest one, and I will not have you inventing troubles to deprive yourself of a triumph.*

*The winter here has been long and my knees are keeping the score. Write to me when the spring fairs open. I should like to see this marvel of*

*yours with my own eyes before you find something in it to worry about.*

*You always do.*

*Your friend,*

*Kohler*